

OUTSIDE THE RAILWAY STATION ERDMAN CAUGHT SIGHT OF THE gloomy facade of some building. High up above, two windows were lit. For an instant it seemed as if the huddled city's eyes were watching him. He walked down the empty street through wet, snowy slush. When he turned the corner past the house with the shining eyes, there was a human shape wavering in the darkness. The street had been deserted, making the appearance of this phantom before him unexpected. It had to have come out of an entryway, or from behind some pillar, if it hadn't just sprouted up from the ground. Behind it were the dark facades of old buildings and in the early morning darkness it was scarcely even possible at first to make out the figure.

*"Khristos voskrese,"* the man shouted. *"Voistinu voskrese."*

He swayed and bent at the waist, and his whirling arms jabbed strange shapes in the air. For an instant Erdman may have been frightened of this bearded man in ragged clothes; he may not have been quite sure what the words meant, what the point was of this bending and arm waving. To be sure, at first he couldn't decide whether the man in front of him was drunk or dangerous or just slightly stupid. He tried to sidestep him, but with a sudden leap that no one would have thought his twisted shape capable of, the other blocked his way. Erdman had the rumble of the train in his ears, the glare of deserted stations in his eyes, and here he was accosted by the empty silence of this street, a dark morning with the dilapidated facades of



unknown buildings and then, suddenly, this contorted face and wobbly human form that refused to let him pass.

He set his suitcase down on the dirty, slushy mess of snow and human footprints. He heard only silence and waited for a human voice to speak to him again out of the red cavity of a mouth before him. Erdman was tired and for a second he felt as though the street were sliding out from under his legs. He ascribed the strange sensation to the long train trip, yet he still propped himself up with a hand against the wall. The other bent at the waist again and stretched his neck out, turning his face upward. Then he straightened and stepped up to him. Erdman could feel the other's warm breath on his face, and he really felt like going. He would turn around and go. He didn't turn around. He didn't pick up his suitcase, and he didn't push the phantom out of the way. Because at that moment, he noticed the other's tiny pupils, which were completely at peace. Completely at peace in that bearded, distorted face, in that body nervously jerking back and forth. Erdman couldn't stop staring at the other's eyes, which were hollow and deep, as though they were the precipice leading into a chasm, as if they concealed a bottomless darkness. He stood there and stared at those eyes and at that face that was furrowed by something inside it, and he could see that these were in fact very quiet, very still eyes. These weren't the eyes of a drunk or an idiot. These were eyes that were afraid of something. Not just anything, but something that was simply, surely going to happen and that could not be avoided. These were Fedyatin's eyes. This was exactly how it had to be. Fedyatin's face and his quiet eyes, his tiny black pupils, and the deep, dark abyss behind them were what he had to see on this morning, with dilapidated buildings in the background, the slushy street, a morning that was quiet from earth to heaven. And Erdman had to start when he saw the dark red stains on the other's coat, when he concluded that those spots were from some blood or other. The street slid slightly from under his feet again, and he held tighter onto the wall.

He may have thought then that he should just turn around and go back where he came from. He didn't turn around and he didn't go back. Who in this world has left a city where he wanted to find out something, based on some vague intuition? Who has ever held back on account of any intuition at all? Intuition exists to propel you even more decisively toward the inevitable. And so that early-morning phantom with the black pupils and dark red stains on its coat was nothing but a drunken, rumpled man with a slightly idiotic face. And so Erdman stayed and he remained standing there in the street even after Fedyatin, still bending ceaselessly, disappeared amid the dark facades of the buildings, after he vanished into the facades, the morning herald and agitator of the resurrection. Erdman stood alone beside a wall on Alexander Street, overwhelmed by the powerful, throbbing silence of that morning, a shuddering silence that hovered over Central Europe, echoed off the walls of streets in Prague, and soundlessly beat and gnawed the shores of Duino. He looked over toward the Franciscan church and waited for a bell up above to ring.

That was early on the morning of the first of January 1938.